

Introduction to Buddhism

A Comparative Religion Training Course
for Da'ees and Researchers



Understand

Experience

Compare

Engage

[1] Buddhist Primary Sources

[2] Academic/Institutional Context

[3] Islamic Comparative Reference



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The Awakening of Siddhartha Gautama

Concept Definition: Buddha = Awakened/Enlightened One (A title, not a personal name)



Tab 1

[1] Buddhist Primary Sources:
Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta

Tab 2

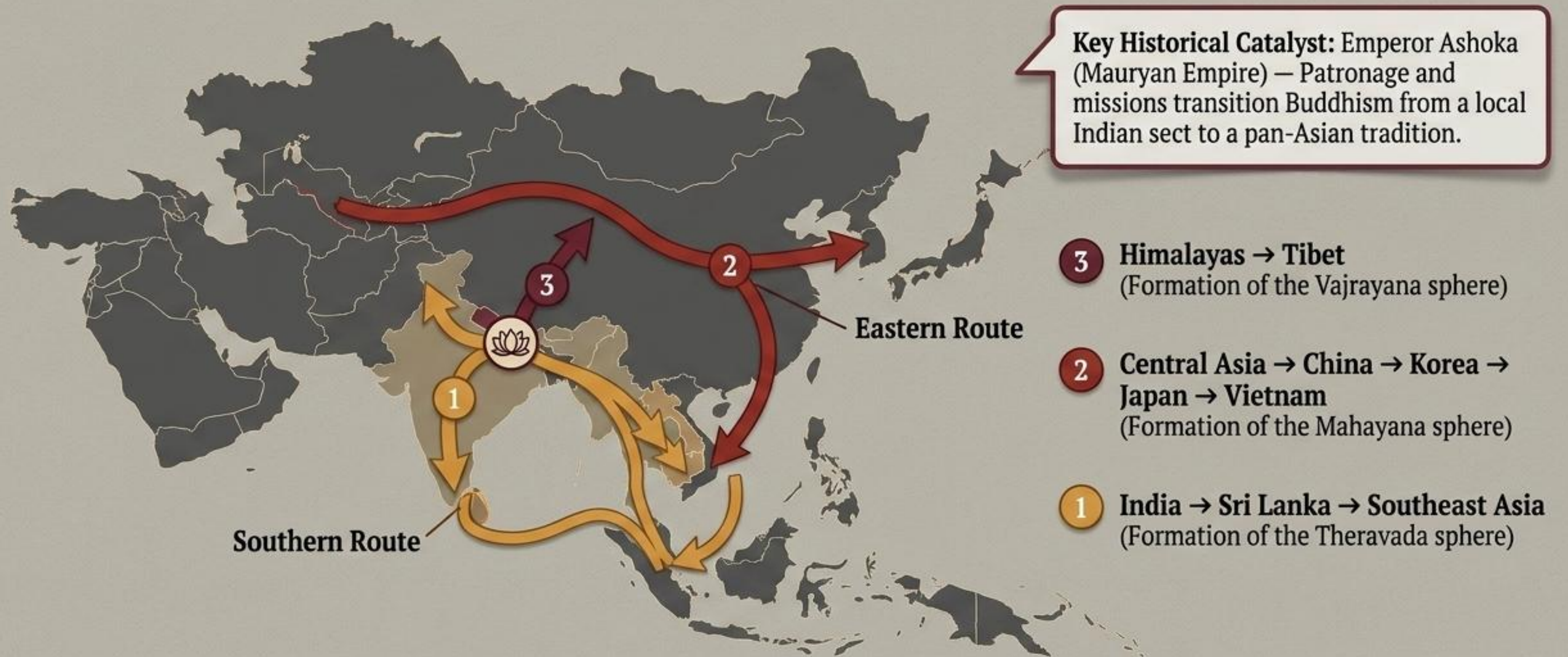
[2] Academic/Institutional Context

Tab 3

[3] Islamic Comparative Reference



The Geographic Dispersion of Buddhism



Tab 1

[1] Buddhist Primary Sources

Tab 2



[2] Academic Context: Historical Timelines

Tab 3



[3] Islamic Comparative Reference

The Foundation: Refuge and Restraint

The Three Jewels/Refuges



I take refuge in the Buddha
(The Teacher/Ideal)

I take refuge in the Dhamma/Dharma
(The Teaching/Truth)

I take refuge in the Sangha
(The Monastic Community)

Note: Refuge implies orientation and practice, not necessarily faith in an Islamic sense.

The Five Precepts for Lay Buddhists

1. Refrain from killing.
2. Refrain from stealing.
3. Refrain from sexual misconduct.
4. Refrain from false speech.
5. Refrain from intoxicants.

Context Note: Modern traditions (e.g., Plum Village) frame these dynamically as Mindfulness Trainings rather than mere prohibitions.

Tab 1

[1] Buddhist Primary Sources

Tab 2

[2] Academic Context: Plum
Village Mindfulness Trainings

Tab 3

[3] Islamic Comparative Reference



The Medical Model of the Four Noble Truths

Quadrant 1: The Symptom (Dukkha) Not just "life is suffering," but the profound unsatisfactoriness, impermanence, and inability of conditioned existence to provide lasting peace.	Quadrant 2: The Pathology/Cause (Taṇhā) Craving. Specifically: sensual craving, craving for existence, craving for non-existence.
Quadrant 3: The Prognosis (Nirvana/Nibbāna) The cessation of craving; ultimate liberation and awakening.	Quadrant 4: The Prescription (Magga) The Noble Eightfold Path.



Tab 1: [1] Buddhist Primary Sources:
Pali Canon / Dhamma Talks



Tab 2: [2]
Academic/Institutional Context

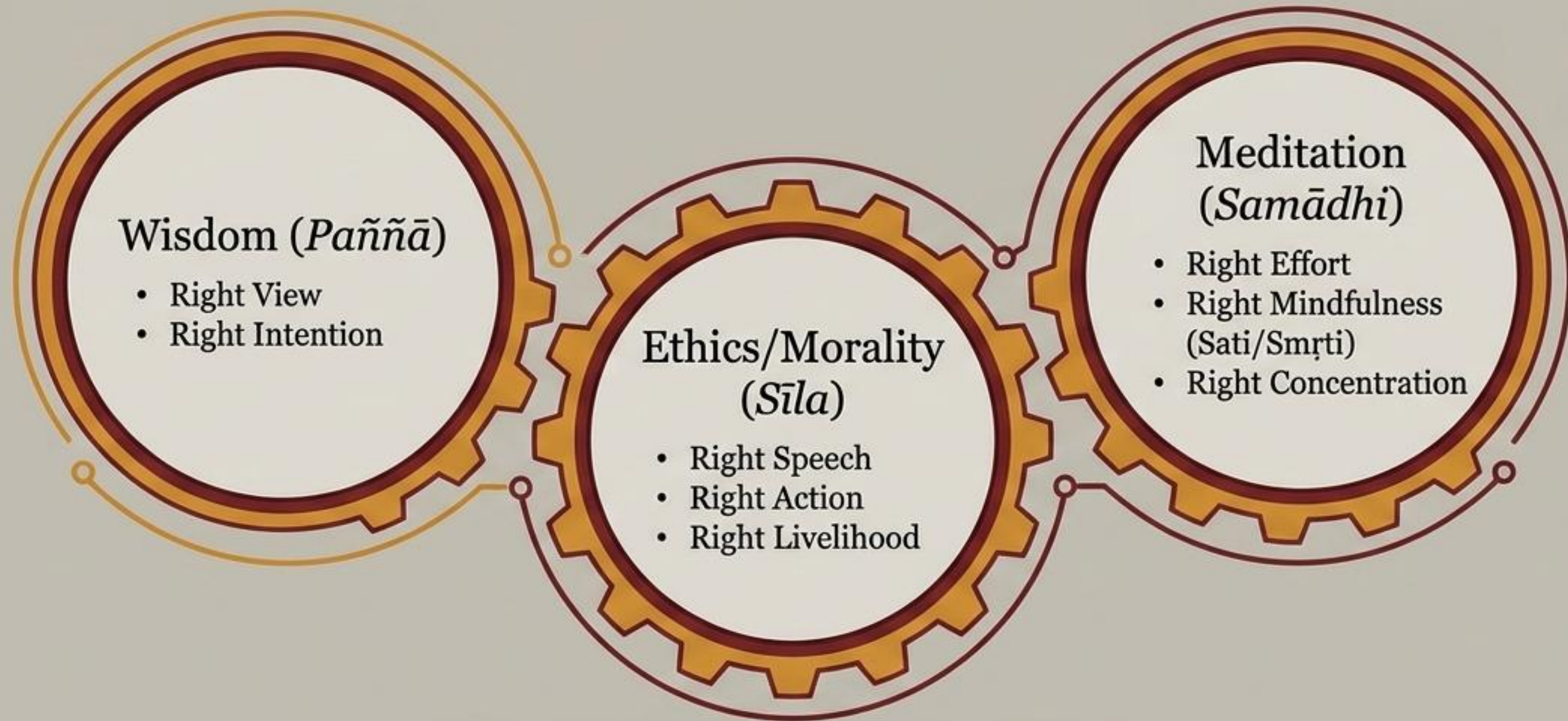


Tab 3: [3] Islamic
Comparative Reference



The Noble Eightfold Path: A Holistic Mechanism

Insight Box: These are interconnected factors of training, not just sequential steps.



[1]

[1] Buddhist Primary Sources

[2]

[2] Academic Context: *Encyclopedia of Buddhism*

[3]

[3] Islamic Comparative Reference

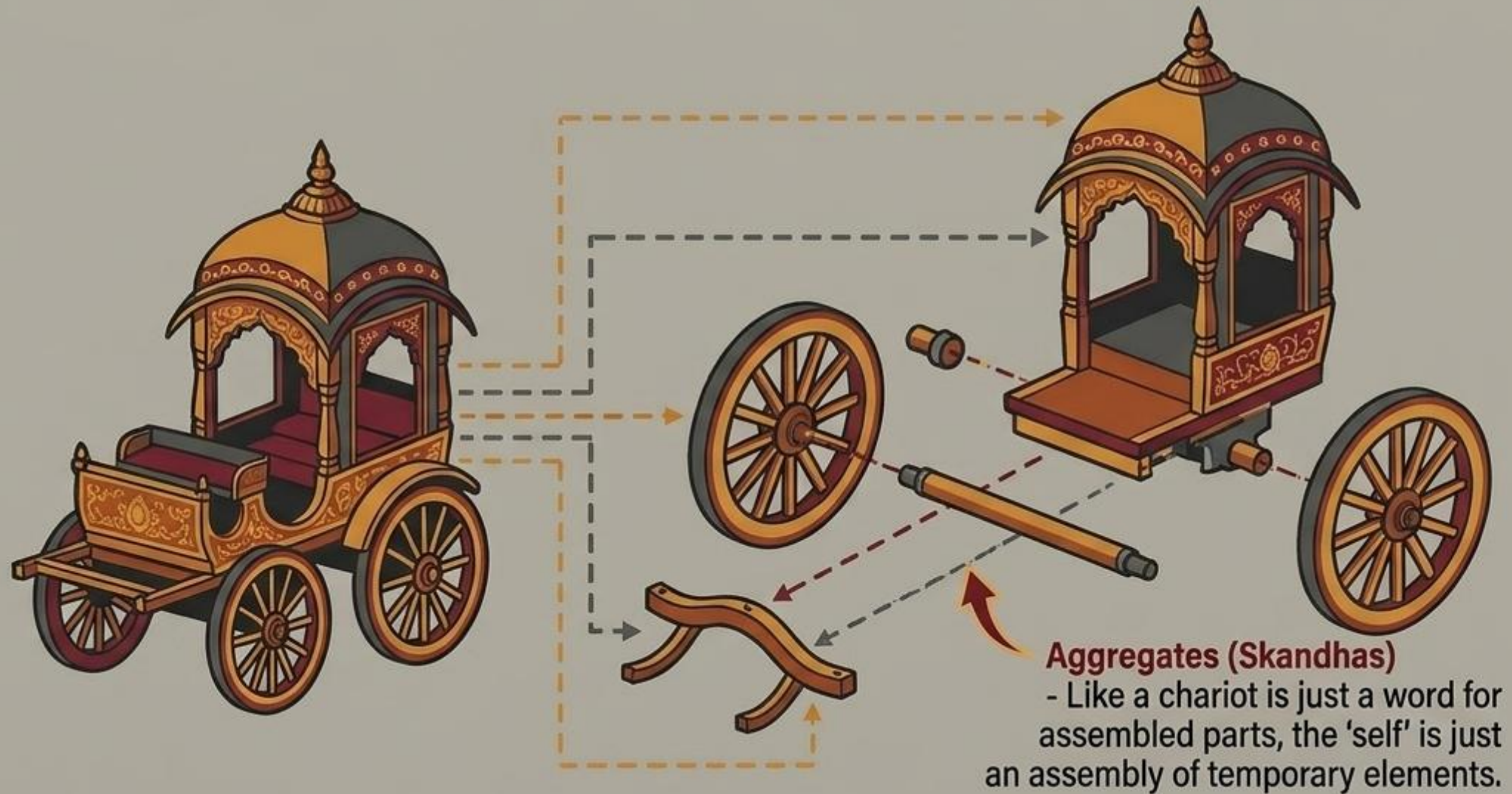


The Three Characteristics of Existence & Deconstructing the Self

1. Anicca: Impermanence
(All conditioned things are in constant flux).

2. Dukkha:
Unsatisfactoriness
(Because things change, they cannot satisfy).

3. Anatta (Not-Self):
The defining Buddhist concept. The self is not a permanent, eternal soul, but a temporary aggregate of physical and mental components.



[1]

[1] Buddhist Primary Sources



[2]

Academic/Institutional Context



[3]

Islamic Comparative Reference



Dependent Origination (Paṭiccasamuppāda)



Core Insight: This wheel explains causation. It is the Buddhist answer to why we suffer and are reborn, showing how ignorance inherently drives the engine of existence. Breaking the link of ignorance (via Nirvana) stops the wheel.



[1] Buddhist Primary Sources



[2] Academic/Institutional Context



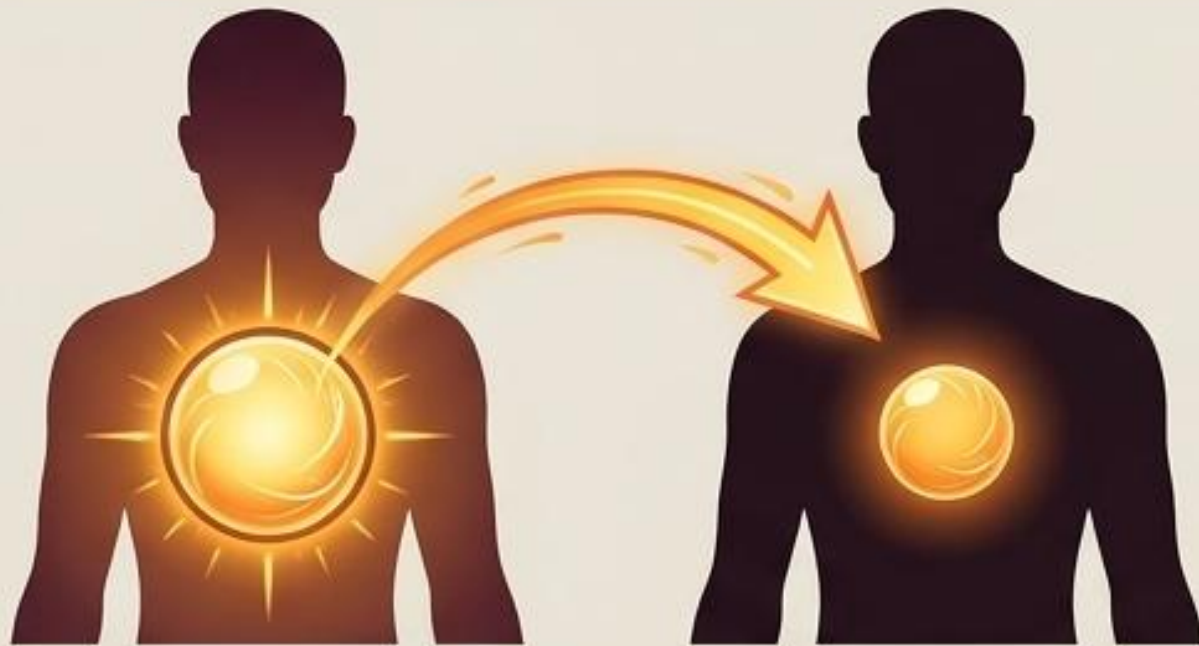
[3] Islamic Comparative Reference

The Mechanics of Samsara: Karma & Rebirth

Karma (Action): Intentional action and its consequences. Crucial Note: Karma ≠ Fate.

The Goal: Escaping Samsara (the cycle of conditioned existence) to achieve Nirvana.

The Hindu Model



Permanent soul (atman) from one body to transfer of a **complete, unchanging** essence.

The Buddhist Model



Rebirth is conditioned continuity. One candle lighting another—transfer of energy/momentum without transferring physical substance. (*What is reborn? The momentum of Karma*).



[1] Buddhist Primary Sources



[2] Academic/Institutional Context



[3] Islamic Comparative Reference

The Three Vehicles: Mapping Buddhist Diversity

	Theravada	Mahayana	Vajrayana
Meaning & Geography	Teaching of the Elders (Sri Lanka, Thailand, Myanmar)	Great Vehicle (China, Japan, Korea, Vietnam)	Diamond/Thunderbolt Vehicle (Tibet, Himalayas)
Scriptural Canon	Pali Tipitaka (Three Baskets)	Sanskrit traditions, Lotus Sutra, Heart Sutra (Form is emptiness)	Tantric texts, Tibetan commentarial corpus
Core Ideal	Arahant (Personal liberation)	Bodhisattva (Postponing liberation to save all sentient beings)	Lama/Bodhisattva via accelerated Tantric paths
Key Practices	Vipassana, Samatha	Zen (Zazen, Koans), Pure Land (Amitabha devotion)	Mantras, Mandalas, Deity Yoga, Prayer Wheels



[1] Buddhist Primary Sources



[2] Academic Classifications



[3] Islamic Comparative Reference

Buddhist Practice in the Real World

The Inner Life



The Monastic Life (Vinaya):

Robes, alms, celibacy, strict discipline. The Sangha preserves the Dhamma.



Meditation Practices:

Samatha (Calm/Concentration), Vipassanā (Insight), Metta (Loving-kindness).

The Outer Life



Ritual & Devotion:

Shrines, offerings (flowers, incense, food), chanting, bowing, and bells.



Pilgrimage Sites:

Lumbini, Bodh Gaya, Sarnath, Kushinagar.



Important Distinction for Daa'ees: Buddha Images. What Buddhists say the image represents (respect, inspiration) vs. what an outside observer may assume it represents (idol worship).



[1] Buddhist Primary Sources



[2] Academic/Institutional Context



[3] Islamic Comparative Reference

From Understanding to Engagement: Common Ground

The Human Search

Ethical Commonalities

Compassion,
charity/generosity,
honesty, self-control,
avoiding intoxicants,
care for others.

The Search for Liberation

- **Buddhism:** Liberation from suffering and *samsara*.
- **Islam:** Salvation through submission to Allah and His mercy.

Analogies of Discipline (Not Equivalencies)

- **Buddhist Path:** *Sīla* (Ethics)
→ *Samādhi* (Concentration)
→ *Paññā* (Wisdom).
- **Islamic Path:** *Īmān* (Faith)
→ *Islām* (Submission) → *Iḥsān* (Excellence).



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The Theological Divide

Buddhism

Islam

The Ultimate Reality

Non-theistic/Diverse. No uncaused Creator God.

Tawhid. Allah is One, Eternal, Uncreated, Creator of all.

The Human Center

Anatta. No permanent soul; an aggregate of elements.

A divinely created human soul/self with individual accountability.

The Core Problem

Ignorance and Craving leading to suffering.

Disobedience/Sin and failing to recognize/worship the Creator.

The Ultimate Solution

Nirvana (Cessation of craving and the cycle of rebirth).

Jannah (Eternal presence and reward through Allah's mercy).



[1] Buddhist Primary Sources



[2] Academic/Institutional Context



[3] Islamic Ref: Qur'an 112:1-4

Concept Clarification: Avoiding False Equivalencies

False Equivalent 1: Karma vs. Qadar

Buddhism: Karma is an impersonal law of moral causation.

Islam: Qadar is the Divine Will and Decree of an active, conscious Creator.

False Equivalent 2: Rebirth vs. Resurrection

Buddhism: Conditioned continuity without a soul continuing through Samsara.

Islam: One earthly life → Barzakh → Bodily Resurrection → Final Judgment.

False Equivalent 3: Meditation vs. Salah

Buddhism: Internal practices of mindfulness, calm, and insight.

Islam: An act of direct worship, submission, and communion with the Creator.



[1] Buddhist Primary Sources

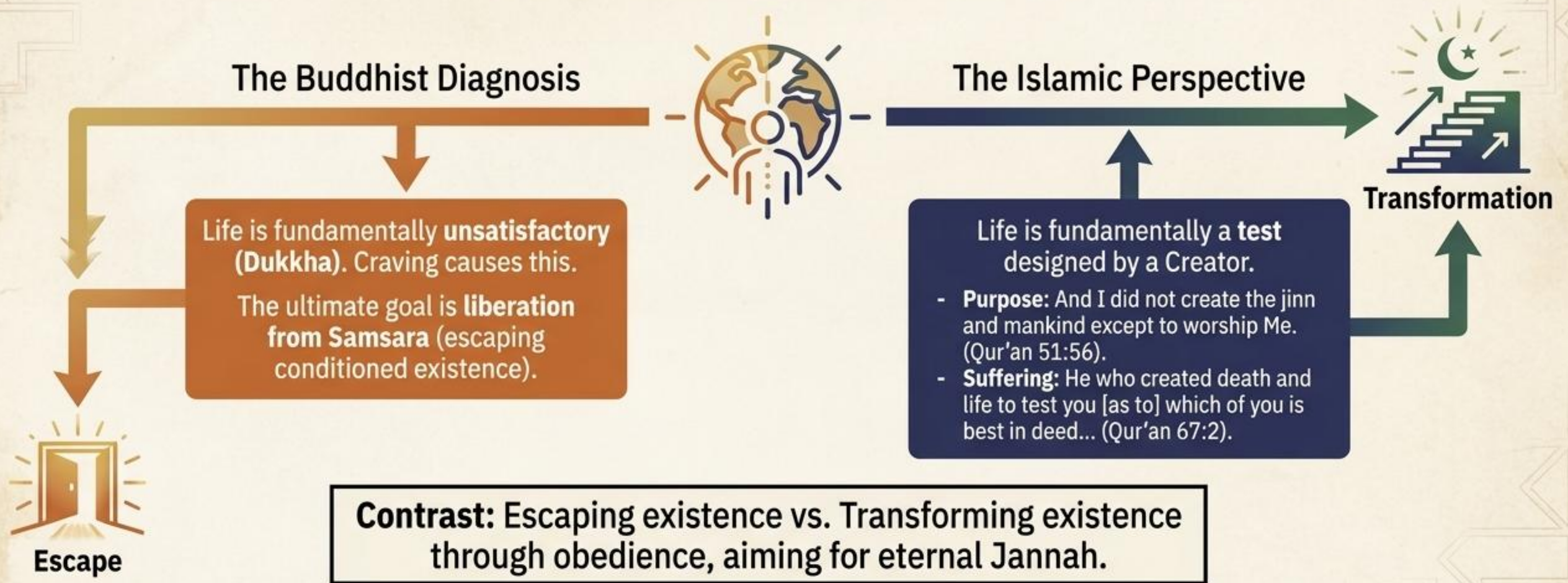


[2] Academic/Institutional Context



[3] Islamic Comparative Reference

The Ultimate Question: Suffering and Purpose



[1] Buddhist
Primary Sources



[2] Academic/
Institutional Context



[3] Islamic Ref:
Qur'an 51:56, 67:2

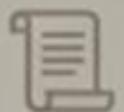
The Methodology of Engagement

Da'wah Dashboard



Recognizing Good Character:
A Da'ee must be able to say, "I admire this quality [e.g., compassion, discipline]" without implying "Therefore your theology is correct."

✗ **What NOT to do:** Never begin with: "Your religion is false", "You worship idols", "Buddha is your god", or "Buddhism is atheism." These immediately close the conversation and misrepresent their actual beliefs.



[1] Buddhist Primary Sources

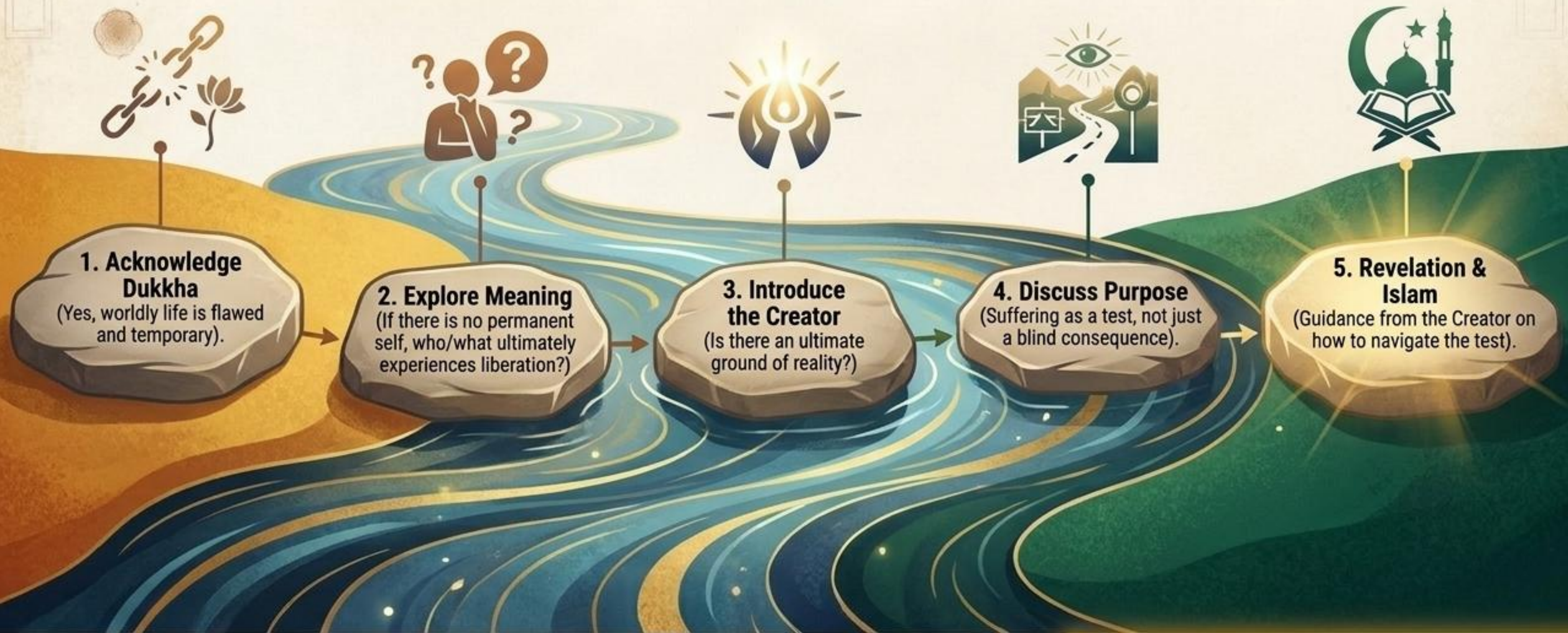


[2] Academic/Institutional Context



[3] Islamic Ref: Qur'an 16:125 - "Invite to the way of your Lord with wisdom".

Dialogue Pathway 1: From Suffering to Purpose



[1] Buddhist Primary Sources

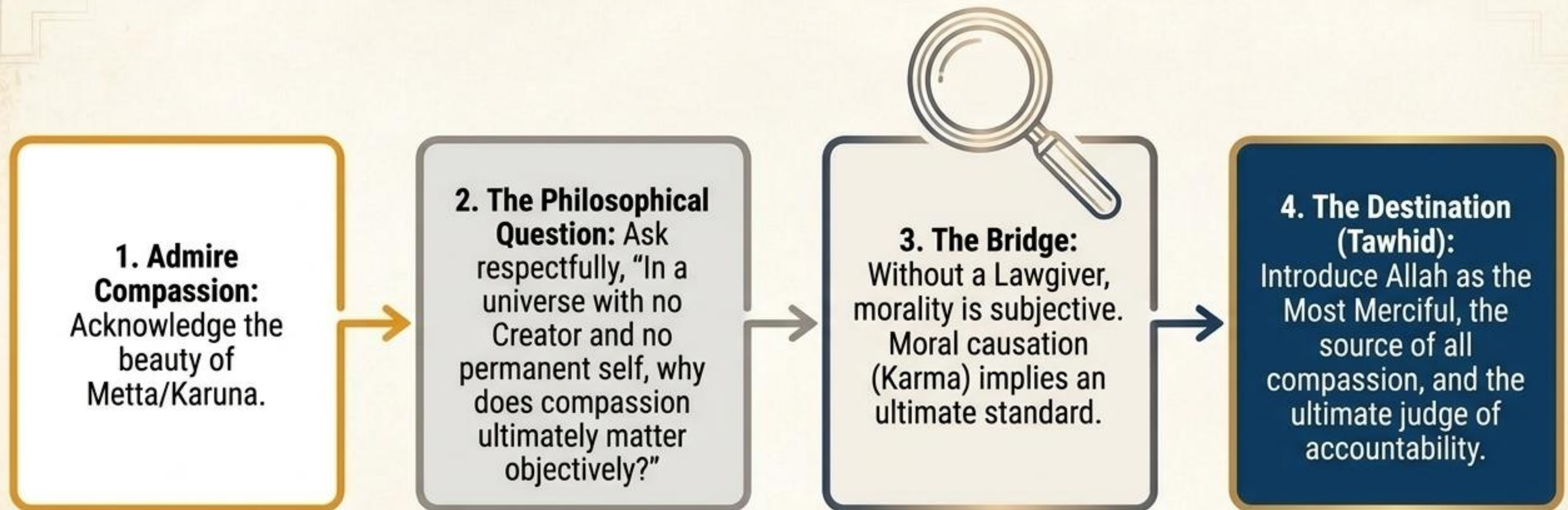


[2] Academic/Institutional Context



[3] Islamic Comparative Reference

Dialogue Pathway 2: From Compassion to *Tawhid*



Dialogue Pathway 3: From Meditation to Worship



[1] Buddhist Primary Sources

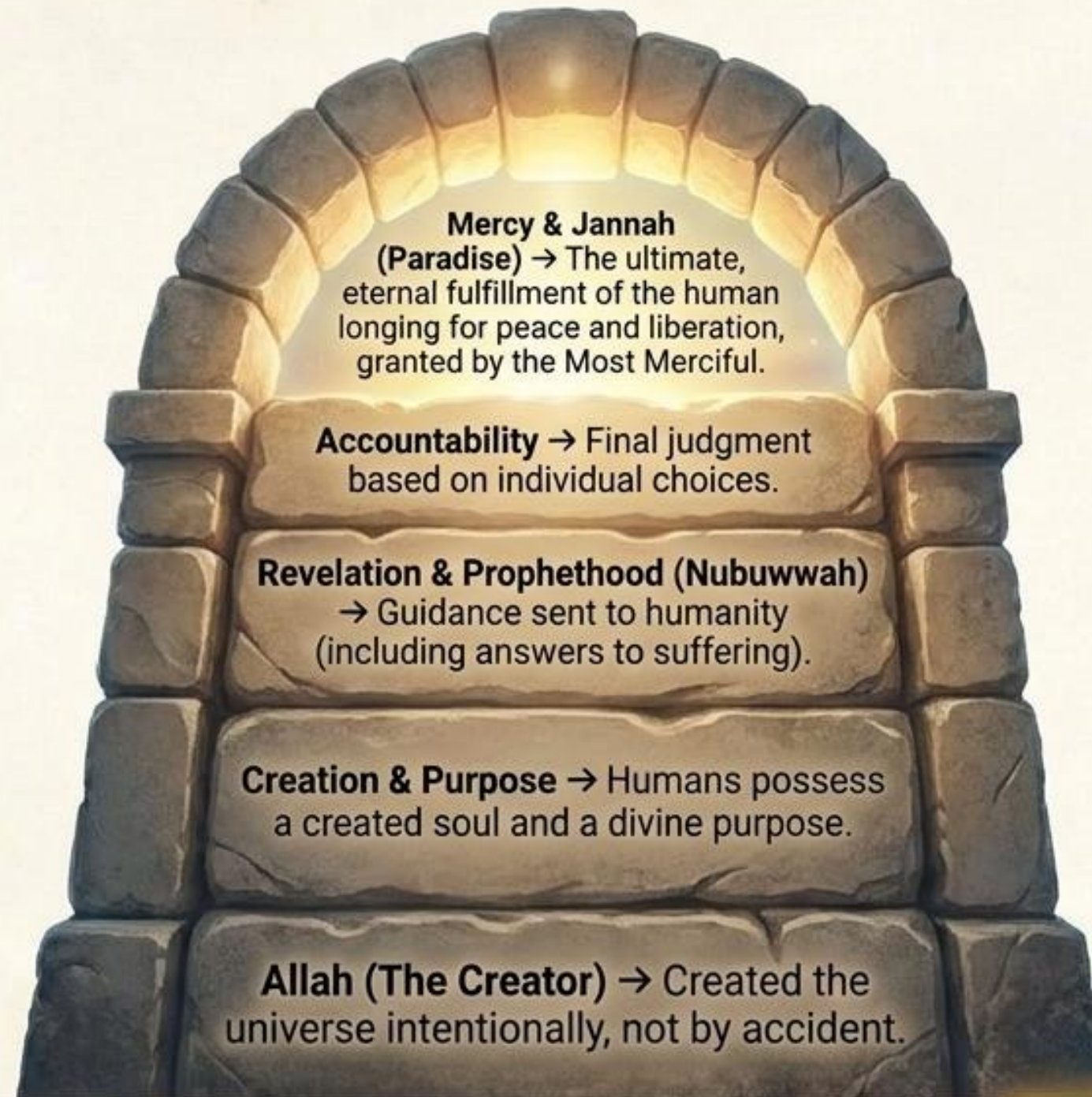


[2] Academic/Institutional Context



[3] Islamic Comparative Reference

The Islamic Answer to the Human Search



Final Reflection

Say: O mankind, there has come to you the truth from your Lord. So whoever is guided is only guided for [the benefit of] his soul...

(Qur'an 10:108)

Closing Question for Daa'ees: What did studying Buddhism teach you about the profound questions human beings ask, and how can you use that understanding to share the beauty of Islam?

الحمد لله رب العالمين

